with global stakeholders."

Toral Patel, Managing Partner at executive search firm Accord Group India, draws a crucial distinction between linguistic polish and strategic clarity. "Accent should almost never matter. Vocabulary sophistication should rarely matter," Patel says. According to Patel, language becomes a structural disadvantage when a leader cannot articulate complex strategic choices, respond to investor concerns, negotiate cross-border acquisitions, or handle crisis communications where nuance matters. "At that point, the issue is not accent or polish, it is communication bandwidth versus stylistic skill."

Citing NASSCOM data, Mangalwedhe says over 60% of India's engineering graduates now originate from Tier-II and Tier-III cities, which also host more than 220 GCC units. Yet, senior CXO roles remain concentrated in Tier-I metros, where board-level and global stakeholder interactions still demand high English proficiency.

THE B-SCHOOL REALITY

As business schools expand intake beyond metro cities, premier management institutes are acutely aware of the changing demographic and linguistic makeup of their classrooms. However, their experiences challenge several common assumptions regarding student struggles and remedial support.

At T.A. Pai Management Institute (TAPMI), Director Debasis Pradhan clarifies that approximately 10% of incoming students come from vernacular-medium backgrounds, a proportion that has remained steady over the past five years. Pradhan says they arrive with strong analytical foundations. "Do they struggle initially? Not really, as they also study English and are quite good," says Pradhan. "They may not be fluent in speaking. Nevertheless, they are extremely good in their written communication and critical thinking."

TAPMI does not offer remedial English because students do not want to be singled out by medium of education, he says. English fluency, he adds, has not negatively affected classroom participation, internships or placements.

At Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Calcutta, Vivek Rajvanshi, a professor in Academic Group Finance and Control, sees language as a brief transition for students entering a rigorous B-school environment.

"Students from diverse geographical, educational and linguistic backgrounds join," Rajvanshi explains. "The vocabulary of management education is different, and some students may initially be less comfortable with it. But after the first few weeks, students are generally able to manage easily. Language confidence matters, but what is more important is their intellectual capability."

IIM Calcutta also uses voluntary pre-MBA bridge programmes and integrated business communication courses. Rajvanshi says peer learning is often more powerful than formal remedial classes because students pick up communication skills through group discussions.

At S.P. Jain School of Global Management, Umesh Kothari, Assistant Dean, notes a marked

